

FORUM

Democratic Caesarism and the Cultural Critique of the Masses in Victorian Britain

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This article reverses prevailing scholarly assumptions according to which in Victorian Britain Caesarism was neglected in both theoretical parlance and public discussion. It shows how intellectuals as ideologically different as Bagehot, Seeley, and Maine, as well as other (less well known) commentators writing in newspapers and periodicals, theorized about Caesarism–Napoleonism primarily according to cultural considerations. This means that they looked at “democratic Caesarism” as a form of society rather than exclusively as a political phenomenon, emphasizing how a series of civilizational deficiencies attributed to the masses enabled Caesarist politics. Moreover, the article argues that these critiques were part of a broader (Arnoldian) antidemocratic discourse that targeted democracy as a cultural desert. Democratic Caesarism was thus seen as being characterized by the masses’ uncultured attitudes, ethical–political irresponsibility, and exaggerated care for materialistic interests. The main goal of this criticism was to expose the damaging consequences of democratic life for British politics and civilization.

Introduction

Caesarism has of late received assiduous coverage in media outlets as well as in political circles.¹ It has also become increasingly popular as an explanatory model amongst legal experts and cultural commentators, notably vis-à-vis its autocratic (American) version arguably threatening the existence of democracy.² Caesarism is equally being studied by a diverse range of scholars engaged in different research fields.³ This is especially

¹See e.g. www.theguardian.com/world/2023/oct/01/red-caesar-authoritarianism-republicans-extreme-right; www.bostonglobe.com/2024/07/17/opinion/trump-vance-fascism-caesarism; www.theguardian.com/us-news/2024/dec/21/curtis-yarvin-trump (all accessed 22 February 2025).

²See e.g. Andrew Majeske, “Donald Trump, American Caesarism, and the Legacy of Leo Strauss,” *American Studies Journal* 65 (2018), at www.asjournal.org/65-2018/donald-trump-american-caesarism-and-the-legacy-of-leo-strauss; Ferdinand Mount, *Big Caesars and Little Caesars: How They Rise and How They Fall—From Julius Caesar to Boris Johnson* (London, 2023). For a balanced historical explanation of the recurrent “specter” of Caesarism in American politics see Iain McDaniel, “American Caesars,” *History Today* 74/10 (2024), 86–9.

³See Francesca Antonini, “Towards an Intellectual History of Caesarism: Introduction,” this issue.

the case in intellectual history, where it has been, and very much still is, the subject of a thriving historiography.⁴

These different strands of literature share several claims about the origins and the nature of Caesarism. They acknowledge that the term was coined by Auguste Romieu in *L'ère des Césars* (1850),⁵ see it as integral to an age of crisis,⁶ describe it as “democracy without liberty,”⁷ and associate it with the plebiscitary endorsement of a strongman.⁸ Moreover, they read Caesarism as a modality of power sustained by a centralized administrative–bureaucratic apparatus, expansionist military policies abroad, and promotion of public works and censorship of the press at home.⁹ Above all, by regarding Caesarism as the affair of a handful of countries (France, Germany, and Italy), they either ignore Britain altogether or maintain that, amongst British thinkers, Caesarism was portrayed as a regime guided by a charismatic leader whose ascendancy over the

⁴See e.g. Arnaldo Momigliano, “Per un riesame della storia dell’idea di cesarismo,” *Rivista storica italiana* 68/2 (1956), 220–29; George L. Mosse, “Caesarism, Circuses, and Monuments,” *Journal of Contemporary History* 6/2 (1971), 167–82; Zvi Yavetz, “Caesar, Caesarism, and the Historians,” *Journal of Contemporary History* 6/2 (1971), 184–201; Peter Baehr, “Accounting for Caesarism: Introduction to Gollwitzer,” *Economy and Society* 16/3 (1987), 341–56; Innocenzo Cervelli, “Cesarismo: alcuni usi e significati della parola (secolo XIX),” *Annali dell’Istituto storico italo-germanico in Trento* 22 (1996), 61–197; Peter Baehr, *Caesar and the Fading of the Roman World: A Study in Republicanism and Caesarism* (New Brunswick, 1998); Baehr, “An ‘Ancient Sense of Politics?’ Weber, Caesarism, and the Republican Tradition,” *European Journal of Sociology* 40/2 (1999), 333–50; Peter Baehr and Melvin Richter, eds., *Dictatorship in History and Theory: Bonapartism, Caesarism, and Totalitarianism* (Cambridge, 2004), esp. 1–26; Melvin Richter, “A Family of Political Concepts: Tyranny, Despotism, Bonapartism, Caesarism, Dictatorship, 1750–1917,” *European Journal of Political Theory* 4/3 (2005), 221–48; Peter Baehr, *Caesarism, Charisma and Fate: Historical Sources and Modern Resonances in the Work of Max Weber* (New Brunswick and London, 2008); Gian Enrico Rusconi, *Cavour e Bismarck: Due leader fra liberalismo e cesarismo* (Bologna, 2011); Iain McDaniel, “Constantin Frantz and the Intellectual History of Bonapartism and Caesarism: A Reassessment,” *Intellectual History Review* 28/2 (2018), 317–38; McDaniel, “The Politics of Historical Economics: Wilhelm Roscher on Democracy, Socialism and Caesarism,” *Modern Intellectual History* 15/1 (2018), 93–122; Francesca Antonini, *Caesarism and Bonapartism in Gramsci* (Leiden and Boston, 2020); Markus Prutsch, *Caesarism in the Post-revolutionary Age: Crisis, Populace and Leadership* (London, 2020); Anton Jäger, “Populism without the People: Fascists, Caesarists, and Democrats in Nadia Urbinati’s *Me the People*,” *History of European Ideas* 48/8 (2022), 1097–101; Cheryl B. Welch, “An Immunity to Authoritarianism? Bagehot, Bryce, and Ostrogorski on the Risk of Caesarism in America,” *Society* 60/4 (2023), 501–15.

⁵See Baehr, *Caesarism*, 32.

⁶See Cervelli, “Caesarism,” 62–3; and Baehr, *Caesarism*, 36. This standpoint is not applicable to economically prosperous post-1850s Britain. See David Eastwood, “The Age of Uncertainty: Britain in the Early Nineteenth Century,” *Transactions of the Royal Historical Society*, 8th series 8 (1998), 91–115, esp. 105, 110–11, 114–15.

⁷Baehr, *Caesarism*, 55 n. 40. This is a curious statement since, well into the nineteenth century, democracy was predominantly combined with equality and license, *not* with liberty.

⁸See e.g. Prutsch, *Caesarism*, 5.

⁹See also Sudhir Hazareesingh, *From Subject to Citizen: The Second Empire and the Emergence of Modern French Democracy* (Princeton, 1998), 29–95; Pierre Rosanvallon, *La démocratie inachevée: Histoire de la souveraineté du peuple en France* (Paris, 2000), 183–221; William Selinger, *Parliamentarism: From Burke to Weber* (Cambridge, 2019), 176–77, 196, 198, 202–3; Pierre Rosanvallon, *Le siècle du populisme: Histoire, théorie, critique* (Paris, 2020), 97–113; Eric Fattor, *Caesarism in the 21st Century: Crisis and Interregnum in World Order* (Exeter, 2024).

people was deemed deleterious to parliamentary politics.¹⁰ At best, they take Walter Bagehot's engagement with Caesarism as exceptional within the Victorian intellectual panorama, neglecting other works and failing to contextualize Bagehot's interventions within that same panorama.¹¹

This article endeavors to improve on the existing literature in two ways. First, it shows that in Victorian Britain Caesarism was amply discussed in both theoretical parlance and public debate.¹² One key reason for this is that Caesarism was not only considered an undemocratic phenomenon shaped by tyrannical governance affecting mostly mainland Europe, but also conceived as a core component of mass democracy in Britain itself.¹³ Instead of accentuating the politico-institutional dimension of Caesarism's illiberality and the role played in it by the philosophy of the *grand homme* (in other words, a top-down critique), many nineteenth-century British commentators emphasized the broader civilizational nature of its illiberality and the way in which the ethical deficiency of the democratic masses enabled Caesarist politics (a bottom-up critique).¹⁴ Their critiques of the sociocultural substratum that facilitated the success of Caesars were articulated with the enlargement of the franchise very much in mind, as with the Second (1867) and Third Reform Acts (1884).¹⁵ Within this framework of democratization, Caesarism was configured as a pathological state of *all* democratic politics and not just of "[l]a démocratie illibérale."¹⁶ In fact, in nineteenth-century Britain, nothing was reputed to be very "liberal" about democracy.

Second, in order to rethink Caesarism's scope as a cultural category,¹⁷ the article pays close attention to leading intellectuals such as Bagehot, John Robert Seeley, and Henry Sumner Maine, who theorized about Caesarism and Napoleonism primarily

¹⁰See Prutsch, *Caesarism*, 151. See also Helena Rosenblatt, *The Lost History of Liberalism: From Ancient Rome to the Twenty-First Century* (Princeton, 2018), 157–68, 177–82.

¹¹See e.g. Baehr, *Caesar and the Fading of the Roman World*, 123–5; Rosanvallon, *La démocratie*, 219; Prutsch, *Caesarism*, 151–4. More receptive to placing Bagehot's ideas in context are Georgios Varouxakis, *Victorian Political Thought on France and the French* (Basingstoke, 2002), 86–102, 165–6; and Gregory Conti, *Parliament the Mirror of the Nation: Representation, Deliberation, and Democracy in Victorian Britain* (Cambridge, 2019), 89 n. 50, 117 n. 168, 122 nn. 186–7. On Bagehot's liberal view on Caesarism see Morena Fini, "Il cesarismo nel pensiero di Walter Bagehot," *Il Pensiero Politico* 16/3 (1983), 445–9.

¹²My pursuit chimes with Alexander Jordan, "Caesarism in Nineteenth-Century British Thought," this issue, which offers a persuasive account of Caesarism's British "relevance."

¹³Despite changing meaning according to chronological and local circumstances, "democracy" referred throughout nineteenth-century Britain to a regime empowering the "people" taken as large swathes of a country's population. On -ism categories see Cesare Cuttica, "To Use or Not to Use ... The Intellectual Historian and the *Isms*: A Survey and a Proposal," *Études épistémè* 13 (2013), Varia, at <https://journals.openedition.org/episteme/268>.

¹⁴"Masses" is a category often difficult to define. Overall, it referred to the working classes (a diverse group formed of a plurality of professional layers as well as regional identities) and to the poor (a class subdivided into deserving, undeserving, idle, able-bodied and worthy).

¹⁵For a reading of (French) Caesarism that considers the role of cultural factors such as "the imagination" and "national character" in it, see Varouxakis, *Victorian Political Thought on France and the French*, esp. 95, 97–8, 102, 164–70. On democracy and Caesarism see the conference Caesarism and Democracy: Historical and Normative Perspectives, at <https://uchv.princeton.edu/events/caesarism-and-democracy-historical-and-normative-perspectives> (accessed 14 September 2025).

¹⁶Rosanvallon, *La démocratie*, 185, 220.

¹⁷On Caesarism's political specificity and novelty see Prutsch, *Caesarism*, 4, 5, 9, 46.

according to *cultural* considerations.¹⁸ Their views—and those of other commentators (including some who voiced their opinions in daily newspapers)—are connected with those of authors such as Matthew Arnold, who, despite not addressing Caesarism directly, similarly condemned the intellectual and ethical credentials of the masses.¹⁹ Their main goal was to expose the (allegedly) damaging consequences of democratic life for British politics *and* civilization.²⁰ They understood “democratic Caesarism”²¹ as a “form of society” (not only as a “form of government”²²) that revealed democracy’s excessive character. Democratic Caesarism was attacked for being antithetical to a Victorian idea of culture that involved more than knowledge: in Arnoldian terms, it meant “[e]xpansion, conduct, science, beauty, manners.”²³ This was an inward condition characterized by an intellectual mind-set and a spiritual standing at odds with the masses’ uncultured attitudes, ethical–political irresponsibility, and exaggerated care for their own material interests.²⁴

Since British criticism of democratic Caesarism remained consistent during Louis-Napoleon’s regime in France (1851–70) and afterwards,²⁵ the following pages proceed chronologically.

Pre-1870: Bagehot–Arnold

In British political discourse, Caesarism meant a plurality of things, depending on where an author chose to lay emphasis. The variety of usages was mirrored by the ideologically composite spectrum of those employing the term and the concept.²⁶ Thus,

¹⁸Some authors used “Caesarism,” others “Napoleonism” and some both to describe the same reality. “Caesarism” worked as an emic and an etic category in that it was employed by contemporary witnesses as well as by later observers.

¹⁹This upbraiding reflected growing anxiety over the educational role of “cultural authority” in democracy. See Stefan Collini, *Public Moralists: Political Thought and Intellectual Life in Britain 1850–1930* (Oxford, 1991), esp. 13–118; H. S. Jones, *Victorian Political Thought* (Basingstoke, 2000), 63–4; and Stefan Collini, *Absent Minds: Intellectuals in Britain* (Oxford, 2006), e.g. 102.

²⁰For most of the authors studied here, “civilisation” primarily referred to aesthetic–ethical cultivation. It sometimes meant material–scientific progress too.

²¹This expression was used in e.g. “Foreign Intelligence. France,” multiple news items, *The Standard*, Monday, 2 April 1866, 6, where the kingdom of Belgium was said to be threatened by France, “the thriving ‘Democratic Caesarism’ which flourishes at its gates.”

²²Angus Hawkins, *Victorian Political Culture: “Habits of Hearts and Minds”* (Oxford, 2015), 13.

²³Quoted in Varouxakis, *Victorian Political Thought on France and the French*, 51.

²⁴This was not the only way of criticizing mass democracy; others included its leading to majority-class legislation, disastrous economic policies, and general mediocrity. It was, though, central in relation to Caesarism. On Victorian antidemocracy see e.g. Benjamin E. Lippincott, *Victorian Critics of Democracy: Carlyle, Ruskin, Arnold, Stephen, Maine, Lecky* (Minneapolis, 1938); Mark Francis and John Morrow, *A History of English Political Thought in the Nineteenth Century* (London, 1994), esp. 250–69; Alan S. Kahan, *Liberalism in Nineteenth-Century Europe: The Political Culture of Limited Suffrage* (Basingstoke, 2003); Gregory Conti, “Democracy Confronts Diversity: Descriptive Representation in Victorian Britain,” *Political Theory* 47/2 (2019), 230–57; Hugo Bonin, “From Antagonist to Protagonist: ‘Democracy’ and ‘People’ in British Parliamentary Debates, 1775–1885,” *Digital Scholarship in the Humanities* 35/4 (2020), 759–75.

²⁵On Charles-Louis Napoleon’s (1808–73) ascent to power, his *coup d’état* of December 1851, and its consequences, see Norman St John-Stevás, “Walter Bagehot and Napoleon III,” in Walter Bagehot, *The Collected Works of Walter Bagehot*, ed. Norman St. John-Stevás, vol. 4 (Cambridge, MA, 1968), 15–24.

²⁶For a comprehensive overview of Caesarism’s occurrences, see Jordan, “Caesarism,” *passim*.

if “Caesarism” was often identified with the “degrading despotism” that had taken hold of the “Roman empire” at a time when it had become corrupt and subject to a humiliating loss of freedom under the yoke of a capricious “tyrant,”²⁷ in other cases Caesarism indicated a form of imperialism (often associated with Benjamin Disraeli’s policies).²⁸ It was also deployed in antithesis to theocracy or church rule.²⁹ In some occurrences still, “Caesarism” was associated with the strong “ties of affection” between a charismatic leader and a gullible mob, as had happened in France, where it conveyed popular “political idolatry” for the sovereign Napoleon.³⁰ This last evaluation, though, did not prevent a few analysts from pointing up Caesarism’s benefits for effective government.³¹

The ascent to power of Louis-Napoleon in France led many in Britain to feel vindicated in their hostility to Continental ideas and politics, of which the French were considered the worst exponents.³² As Jonathan Parry has explained, “the ease with which Napoleon, specifically, exploited universal suffrage to entrench his despotism strengthened the case of those who opposed major franchise changes.”³³ Victorian antidemocrats underscored that what had happened in France proved the dangers of “democratic tyranny.”³⁴ In fact, despite important differences in terms of political institutions and general social mood in the two countries, some British observers thought France was not the only country at risk of being swept over by democratic Caesarism. Whether bluntly warning that things were heading in a similar direction in a Britain confronted by the rising tide of democratic enfranchisement or observing events in France more detachedly, several writers used Caesarism as a platform from which they addressed, and speculated on, the ruinous consequences of mass democracy over politics as well as culture.

²⁷“France: The Emperor and the French Clergy,” *Hertford Mercury and Reformer*, Saturday, 27 Oct. 1860, 4.

²⁸See e.g. William S. Jevons, *Elementary Lessons in Logic* (1870) (London and New York, 1893), Lesson vi, 47.

²⁹See e.g. “Louis Napoleon and the French Priesthood,” *Liverpool Daily Post*, Tuesday, 7 Sept. 1858, 8.

³⁰“France under Louis Napoleon,” *Westminster Review* 70/138 (1858), 167–94, at 172. The article spoke of “the fascination exercised by the name of Napoleon on the illiterate mass of the rustic population”; indeed, Napoleon held “a transcendental spell ... on the simple minds” of the French people. *Ibid.*, 168.

³¹James Anthony Froude’s *Caesar: A Sketch* (1879) presented Caesar as “a brilliant democratic general.” Quoted in Frank M. Turner, “British Politics and the Demise of the Roman Republic: 1700–1939,” *Historical Journal* 29/3 (1986), 577–99, at 593.

³²See Jonathan P. Parry, “The Impact of Napoleon III on British Politics, 1851–1880,” *Transactions of the Royal Historical Society*, 6th series 11 (2001), 147–75, at 147–52. For British “hostility to the French and admiration for the Germans” between 1851 and 1870 see Peter Mandler, *The English National Character: The History of an Idea from Edmund Burke to Tony Blair* (New Haven and London, 2006), 87.

³³Parry, “The Impact of Napoleon III,” 163.

³⁴Hawkins, *Victorian Political Culture*, 224–5. On the French conditions facilitating Caesarism—a mixture of faulty “national character” and institutional shortcomings—see Walter Bagehot, “Letter IV: On the Aptitude of the French Character for National Self-Government,” in “Letters on the French *Coup d’État* of 1851,” in *The Collected Works of Walter Bagehot*, 4: 54–62 (this letter is dated Paris, 29 Jan. 1852); and Walter Bagehot, “Letter V: On the Constitution of the Prince-President,” in *ibid.*, 63–70, at 63–4 (this letter is undated).

In late 1851, the journalist and political commentator Walter Bagehot (1826–77) witnessed, firsthand from Paris, the *coup d'état* of Louis-Napoleon, whom he praised a few months later in *The Inquirer* (January–March 1852). As a result, Bagehot became unpopular amongst British liberals.³⁵ His tribute to Louis-Napoleon has divided historians: for some, Bagehot supported Caesarism;³⁶ for others, he was no friend of Caesarist politics.³⁷ Less explored is what Bagehot's opinions of Caesarism reveal about his broader views of democracy and how they relate to those of other nineteenth-century British thinkers.³⁸

To understand Bagehot's assessment of Caesarism and democracy, one would search in vain for a theoretical (let alone normative) definition of these two categories in his works. Instead, it is crucial to concentrate on his comprehensively negative depiction of “the inferior people” who had made Napoleon III “really strong and really popular.”³⁹ In describing the working classes as an unthinking mass deprived of political intelligence and of culture, who were easily manipulated by demagogues like Louis-Napoleon, Bagehot was being neither especially innovative nor extreme within nineteenth-century antidemocratic parameters. For decades, British commentators had argued that, since it was marred by the masses' violent opinions, servility and mediocrity, democracy was “the parent of tyranny and licence.”⁴⁰

Georgian and Victorian political writers often looked at American democracy as an anti-model, something unfit to be tried out in Britain.⁴¹ Again, Bagehot followed suit, but this time gave the idea an original twist. He held democracy, with its mobbish customs, responsible for having turned the US into “an almost unmitigated *ochlocracy*.”⁴² The latter, which meant “mob rule,” referred to Polybius' cyclical theory of governments as advanced in the second century BCE. Polybius had argued that each of

³⁵For criticism issued soon after Bagehot's seven letters from Paris see “Augustus Redivivus,” *The Examiner*, Saturday, 30 Oct. 1852, 691.

³⁶See St John-Stevas, “Bagehot,” 15–24; and Gian Mario Bravo, “Il fallimento della politica: Marx e gli altri: a proposito di Luigi Bonaparte,” in Manuela Ceretta, ed., *Bonapartismo, Cesarismo, e Crisi della Società: Luigi Napoleone e il colpo di stato del 1851* (Florence, 2003), 3–22, at 14.

³⁷See Joseph Hamburger, “Bagehot, Walter,” *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* (ODNB), at www.oxforddnb.com (accessed 12 September 2023). Bagehot's early endorsement of the 1851 coup (and of Bonapartism as a regime fitting France's character) and his later critique of Napoleon III (and of his regime as unsuitable to Britain) in the 1860s did not alter his overall negative view of democracy.

³⁸It has been suggested that Bagehot hailed Caesarism “a distinct form of government” rather than something every polity grounded on extended popular suffrage experienced. Nicholas Cole, “Republicanism, Caesarism, and Political Change,” in Miriam Griffith, ed., *A Companion to Julius Caesar* (Chichester, 2009), 418–30, at 427.

³⁹Walter Bagehot, “Letter I: The Dictatorship of Louis Napoleon,” in “Letters on the French *Coup d'État* of 1851,” in *The Collected Works of Walter Bagehot*, 4: 29–34, at 30 (this letter is dated Paris, 8 Jan. 1852). On Louis-Napoleon as he who saved France from internal turmoil and fostered economic prosperity see *ibid.*, 33; for the same idea see Walter Bagehot, “Letter II: The Morality of the *Coup d'État*,” in *ibid.*, 35–44, at 36–7 (this letter is dated Paris, 15 Jan. 1852).

⁴⁰John Russell, *An Essay on the History of the English Government and Constitution* (1821), new edn (London, 1873), 269.

⁴¹See David P. Crook, *American Democracy in English Politics 1815–1850* (Oxford, 1965), esp. 109–36.

⁴²Walter Bagehot, “What May Be in America” (*The Economist*, 17 Aug. 1861), in *The Collected Works of Walter Bagehot*, 4: 271–6, at 272–3, my emphasis.

the three traditional forms of government experienced a process of *anakyklosis* (cyclic decay), whereby kingship degenerated into tyranny and aristocracy into oligarchy, and, following “outrages and iniquities,” democracy turned into “Ochlocracia.”⁴³

In deploying the Polybian term, which had been revitalized during the English Civil Wars, where it was framed as an offshoot of Caesar-inspired politics from which a strong dictator was predicted to emerge and act as England’s savior,⁴⁴ Bagehot set the tone for a thorough critique of democracy. Despite obvious contextual differences, ochlocracy and Caesarism served to portray a dismal image of what happened when enlarged democracy and tyrannical aspirations met. They were both targeted for encouraging the politicization of the ignorant multitude. As Bagehot specified, the reason for this ochlocratic turn was that the “only half educated,” or indeed outright “ignorant,” “masses” had grown “everywhere omnipotent.”⁴⁵ This situation showed that Napoleon’s Caesarism, as Bagehot put it, was a “Benthamite” (i.e. democratic) despotism aiming to provide as much popular “happiness” as possible. No divinely appointed ruler, Napoleon was “the people’s agent” who had been inspired by “the first ... democratic despot:” the “demagogue ruler” Caesar.⁴⁶

Aware of living through “an age of preeminently democratic tendencies and temper,”⁴⁷ Bagehot drew on another classical trope when explaining that, meek and pliable when playing “servant,” the Caesarist–ochlocratic masses became “capricious, exacting, and relentless” when being “master.”⁴⁸ This crippling condition affected the French emperor directly in that—as Bagehot clarified—he depended on “*the support* of the lower classes” (urban and rural), having to rely on “the right of numbers” in order to govern. In fact, the French ruler could not “offend” the masses, having to “please” them instead.⁴⁹ Conscious that he could not hold back “the might of the popular masses,” Louis-Napoleon pursued his Caesarist project by setting up a dominion of “one man” grounded on “the great body of the people.” He exploited the masses’ passions but channeled them in the directions he desired. As in an ochlocracy, so in a democratic Caesarism, power called on “brute force,” which, for Bagehot, constituted the biggest challenge to a “civilisation” founded on “moral and intellectual” attributes rather than on “material” premises.⁵⁰

⁴³Polybius, *The History of Polybius the Megalopolitan ... Translated into English by Edward Grimeston* (London, 1633), Bk. vi, 283. On Polybius’ cyclical sequence see David E. Hahm, “Kings and Constitutions: Hellenistic Theories,” in Christopher Rowe and Malcolm Schofield, eds., *The Cambridge History of Greek and Roman Political Thought* (Cambridge, 2005), 457–76.

⁴⁴On ochlocracy in seventeenth-century England see Cesare Cuttica, “Democracy and Crisis in the 1640s in England: The Ochlocratic Moment,” in Cesare Cuttica and László Kontler (with Clara Maier), eds., *Crisis and Renewal in the History of European Political Thought* (Leiden and Boston, 2021), 106–26.

⁴⁵Bagehot, “What May Be in America,” 273.

⁴⁶Walter Bagehot, “Caesarism as It Now Exists” (*The Economist*, 4 March 1865, 249–50), in *The Collected Works of Walter Bagehot*, 4: 111–16, at 111.

⁴⁷Walter Bagehot, “The Emperor of the French” (*The Economist*, 28 Nov. 1863, 1322–3), in *The Collected Works of Walter Bagehot*, 4: 101–4, at 102.

⁴⁸Walter Bagehot, “The Emperor of the French” (*The Economist*, 5 Dec. 1863, 1348–9), in *The Collected Works of Walter Bagehot*, 4: 105–9, at 105.

⁴⁹Bagehot, “The Emperor,” 105, original emphasis. He was also dependent on “the instrumentality of bayonets.” Ibid.

⁵⁰Ibid., 108.

This last passage is particularly important because it denotes a way of thinking vis-à-vis democracy similar to that expounded by Bagehot's close friend, the poet and critic Matthew Arnold (1822–88).⁵¹ Both intellectuals addressed democracy's cultural dimension, not just its typology of government or its institutional arrangements. They combated democracy as a culture of the masses. Molded by an elitist search for the right antidotes to philistinism and materialism, their vision of culture bespoke an exhortation to individuals to attain self-governance. This critique of democracy signified a positive program for creating responsible citizens. Similarly to Samuel Smiles's philosophy expounded in the well-known *Self-Help* (1859), which aimed to equip individuals with an elevated spiritual character through education and reading, they conceived of government of the self as a solution to the perils of Caesarism (and the uncertainties intertwined with mass democracy).⁵² In fact, Smiles too attacked Caesarism as "a doctrine which, if taken as a guide, must, by destroying the free conscience of a community, speedily prepare the way for any form of despotism." For Smiles, "Caesarism" equaled "human idolatry in its worst form—a worship of mere power" against which it was necessary to erect scientific and literary barriers.⁵³

As the author of an article on France from October 1858 observed, one of the greatest threats posed by the Caesarist regime was "the degradation of intelligence" it brought about.⁵⁴ At the same time, he reckoned, Caesarism thrived on the superstitions of the masses.⁵⁵ Such a mutually reinforcing interplay was exemplified by Napoleon's own strategy. Napoleon had opposed the enlightened few and had striven "to ally himself with those masses whose interests he affirmed had been shamefully neglected by the superciliousness of vain pedants."⁵⁶ Acting as "the people's delegate elected to acquire for them their rights," Napoleon had turned "these rights" into "the stalking-horse for his ambition." Above all, he had made "the conceited arrogance of barren pedantry ... the war-cry of a crusade against education, the corner-stone of all free government." The Caesarist Napoleon had recognized that, "unless removed and positively crushed," culture would "prove the block against which his system would be dashed to pieces."⁵⁷ Therefore he had suppressed the most excellent and independent

⁵¹ Although Arnold did not explicitly refer to Caesarism, his stance towards democratic developments in Britain helps to frame Victorian fears of democratic Caesarism and the cultural–political–ideological terrain from which it emerged.

⁵² This is not to affirm that Arnold's and Bagehot's outlooks on culture coincided: in fact, the latter—rather unfairly—targeted the former's cultural project as static and detrimental to dynamism, indeed as too academic. See Jones, *Victorian Political Thought*, 67. It remains nevertheless true that their cultural criticisms of mass authoritarian democracy had more in common than their general readings of cultural authority might indicate. On Arnold's rejection of democratic philistinism as the result of his aristocratic "perfectionism" see Alan S. Kahan, "Arnold, Nietzsche and the Aristocratic Vision," *History of Political Thought* 33/1 (2012), 125–43.

⁵³ Samuel Smiles, *Self-Help; With Illustrations of Character, Conduct, and Perseverance*, 2nd edn (London, 1866), 4; the passages on "Caesarism and Self-Help" are not in the first edition from 1859.

⁵⁴ "France under Louis Napoleon," 173.

⁵⁵ Because of "their profound ignorance," the mobs were completely in thrall to "superstitious notions" of the greatness of the "infallible" Napoleon and his ability to infuse France with "a golden age of plenty and prosperity." *Ibid.*, 169.

⁵⁶ *Ibid.*, 173.

⁵⁷ *Ibid.*, 173.

newspapers, so that those still in operation inculcated “doctrines of absolute government, by clumsy eulogies of Cæsarism as incarnate in the dynasty of Bonaparte.”⁵⁸ Sustained by the credulous masses of France, the article continued, “Bonapartism” flourished thanks to ignorance, aiming “to lower the intellectual vigour of the nation, by breaking up the volume of its thought.”⁵⁹ Key to this scathing appraisal of Caesarism was the observation that, in mass democracy, “public opinion” oscillated very rapidly from one extreme to another, so that the French leader went from being branded “a political clown and adventurer” to suddenly becoming revered “as a mysterious mouthpiece of recondite policy.”⁶⁰

The Francophile Arnold elaborated further on these themes in an essay dedicated to “Democracy” from 1861. He maintained that “[t]he difficulty for democracy is, how to find and keep high ideals,” given that the “bulk” of the people composing it did not seek to achieve “greatness, high feeling, and fine culture” (something that until then the aristocracy had provided to the polity).⁶¹ With the advent of democracy however, the mass ceased “to be a lower order” and acquired agency. As Arnold saw things, “the grave question” was exactly whether the “democratic” society then emerging would be capable of adopting cultural and ethical standards “higher” than those held by “ordinary” men. Like Bagehot, Arnold believed that empowering “the multitude,” “with no adequate ideal to elevate or guide the multitude,” was extremely dangerous.⁶²

In 1865, Bagehot provided a concrete example of such a deleterious scenario. He argued that, although Napoleon’s Caesarist regime was “really the *best finished* democracy which the world has ever seen,” for this “absolute government” had been administratively efficient, it had nonetheless revealed a major deficiency: a strong attachment to “material prosperity.” Having been able to satisfy “[t]he welfare of the masses,” caring for “the present good of the multitude,” and providing “the bread and meat of the people,” the emperor had demonstrated a degree of sagacity unknown to other governments.⁶³ However, Bagehot explained, democratic Caesarism had turned out to be a regime of the “present” addressing “coarse” needs; it was not a regime of the future in that it dismissed “refined purposes.”⁶⁴ Grounded on the uncultured masses, such a government had feet of clay and could not last.

The cultural critique of democratic Caesarism was a constant of public debate: it was articulated by other and less well-known commentators. An article in the *Saturday Review* (1865) made clear that “Caesarism seldom obtains the suffrages of the educated classes,” securing instead “the suffrages of the people, because it promises to earn, and sometimes does actually earn, them.” Having “neither capacity nor taste for political life, still less for the ... dignity of office,” the masses—this piece implied—entrusted a

⁵⁸Ibid., 174.

⁵⁹Ibid., 191.

⁶⁰Ibid., 167. On the alleged differences between Bonapartism and Louis-Napoleon’s Caesarism see Rosanvallon, *La démocratie*, 183, 184–5, also 217–18.

⁶¹Matthew Arnold, “Democracy,” in *Matthew Arnold: Culture and Anarchy and Other Writings*, ed. Stefan Collini (Cambridge, 1993), 1–25, at 14.

⁶²Ibid., 14, 15.

⁶³Bagehot, “Caesarism as It Now Exists,” 112, original emphasis.

⁶⁴Ibid., 113.

demagogic leader with “all the power and prestige, in the belief that he will look to the material interests of those upon whose shoulders he is carried to the throne.”⁶⁵

The prism through which this criticism was voiced varied according to an author’s priorities, but its underlying motif remained the same. Thus, connecting Roman “Caesarism” with Napoleon’s “Caesarism,” the Liberal politician and historian Edward Augustus Freeman underlined how a depraved democracy had established Caesar’s despotic regime.⁶⁶ Since representative government was back then “unheard of,” the only solution to prevent further popular degeneration had been empowering Caesar.⁶⁷ The latter had become “the leader of a mob not worthy of being called a people” because it did not know how to conduct “any peaceable discussion,” resorting to “weapons, as the best argument they could find to settle their differences.”⁶⁸ The taming of the uncouth rabble by the strongman was deceptive, though: Caesar’s seemingly “peaceable government,” exactly like that of “Buonaparte at this time,” was—Freeman stated—“the most corrupting of all governments.”⁶⁹ This was so because Caesar and Napoleon did not imprison, murder, or plunder. They operated more subtly: they put “people into a sort of fool’s paradise,” giving “them a prosperity like that of the hog in his sty.” Caesarism succeeded because, under its yoke, “people may eat and drink and get rich,” even if—Freeman concluded—it “crushed” “every noble aspiration” and killed all “political or literary life,” so that there remained “nothing for men to do but fall down and worship as they are bid,” learning “to hug their chains.”⁷⁰ For Freeman, “the real sin of Caesarism, Buonapartism, or whatever we may call it” was that it corrupted the masses irreversibly, accelerating overall civilizational decay. Freeman’s lesson was clear: blinded by base interests and marred by cultural poverty, the lower orders showed their “reverence” for the wrong kind of “great men.”⁷¹

The explicit association between mass democracy and Caesarism was made a few months later in a climate increasingly dominated by fears of ongoing democratic processes: America and France had taught Britain an important “lesson,” namely “that if you will have democracy, you must have something like Caesarism to control it.”⁷² The

⁶⁵“M. Mazzini and Caesarism,” *Saturday Review*, 22 July 1865, 101–2, at 102. For the same perspective (only harsher) on the culturally damaging spirit introduced by democracy (the realm of “blockheadism, gullibility, amenability to beer and balderdash”), see Thomas Carlyle, *Shooting Niagara: And After?* (London, 1867), 10.

⁶⁶Edward A. Freeman, “Caesar, His Forerunners and Followers,” in “II. Annual Report, Trinity Term 1865,” *Proceedings of the Oxford Architectural and Historical Society*, new series 2 (1864–71), 19–36, at 35.

⁶⁷*Ibid.*, 27–8.

⁶⁸*Ibid.*, 29.

⁶⁹*Ibid.*, 35.

⁷⁰*Ibid.*, 35.

⁷¹*Ibid.*, 36. Freeman, though, did not oppose democracy per se (see *ibid.*, 23), becoming in fact a supporter of it (in its elective-constitutional form) later in life. See James Kirby, “From Tractarian to Democrat: The Intellectual Formation of E. A. Freeman,” in G. A. Bremner and Jonathan Conlin, eds., *Making History: Edward August Freeman and Victorian Political Culture* (Oxford, 2015), 31–45. On Freeman’s support for “many of the changes wrought by” the 1867 bill and for his opposition to “many” of them as “imperfect, and [to] others [as] distinctly evil,” see *The Life and Letters of Edward A. Freeman*, ed. William Richard Wood Stephen, 2 vols. (London and New York, 1895), 1: Ch. 6, 1867–1869, 348–51.

⁷²“The Coming Session: The Question of Reform,” *Supplement to the Exeter and Plymouth Gazette*, Friday, 26 Jan. 1866, 2. This was a short extract taken from “Art. IX,” *Quarterly Review* 119/237 (1866), 250–80, at

article—which expressed great terror at the prospect that the ignorant classes, instead of “the educated classes,” will wield political power—opined that “a government” that depended on “the House of Commons” was “only possible so long as that House of Commons is the organ of an educated minority,” *not* if it depended on “a legislature chosen from the lower class.”⁷³ Similarly, with the “question of Parliamentary Reform” at the forefront of public discussion, an article in the *Pall Mall Gazette* asked whether Britain’s “balanced [politico-constitutional] system” would be maintained or “whether it is to be delivered over to modern democracy or to Caesarism.”⁷⁴

It was in the thick of the political battles surrounding the Second Reform Act (1867)—which gave the right to vote to all male urban householders, to male lodgers paying ten pounds in rent a year for unfurnished accommodation, and to agricultural tenants⁷⁵—that Arnold’s *Culture and Anarchy* (1869) pitted culture against the creeds of the democratic masses.⁷⁶ To begin with, Arnold was convinced that this group was equipped with only a lower self, which was instinctual rather than cultured.⁷⁷ He dismissed the many as incapable of grasping truth, underscoring the incompatibility between “the best reason and spirit of man” and the “natural taste for the bathos” informing the masses.⁷⁸ Then Arnold argued that, since “the raw and unkindled” “inferior classes” were not gifted with “sweetness and light,” they remained in thrall to “hatred” and “machinery.”⁷⁹ A stark instance of these features, according to Arnold, was the “rowdysim” of the democratic crowds that had rioted in Hyde Park in 1866.⁸⁰ The “assertion” of one’s “personal liberty,” galvanized by the democratic spirit, yielded dire consequences: amongst them was a sense of entitlement spearheading the masses onto a path that threatened Britain’s stability.⁸¹ For Arnold, it was necessary to shape men with “beauty” (“sweetness”) and “intelligence” (“light”), in order to halt the same brutal force typical of the Caesarist masses that Bagehot had identified with the high road to (French) political disorder.⁸²

279–80. Tellingly, the parts reprinted were those dealing with democratic Caesarism. The original article was by the future Conservative PM Robert Gascoyne-Cecil, an inveterate antidemocrat who opposed the extension of the franchise in the 1860s and a self-declared investigator of states’ pathologies. See Paul Smith, “Cecil, Robert Arthur Talbot Gascoyne-, third marquess of Salisbury,” *ODNB* (accessed 7 October 2025). I thank Alex Jordan for the article’s attribution.

⁷³“The Coming Session,” 2.

⁷⁴“Political Frivolity,” *Pall Mall Gazette*, 25 Oct. 1867, 1429.

⁷⁵For all details see Hawkins, *Victorian Political Culture*, 253–62.

⁷⁶*Culture and Anarchy*’s essays had first appeared in the *Cornhill Magazine* in 1867–8.

⁷⁷See Matthew Arnold, “Culture and Anarchy: An Essay in Political and Social Criticism,” in *Matthew Arnold: Culture and Anarchy and Other Writings*, 53–187, at 181–2.

⁷⁸*Ibid.*, 113, 112; see also *ibid.*, 185.

⁷⁹*Ibid.*, 79, 80.

⁸⁰*Ibid.*, 84–5.

⁸¹*Ibid.*, 86, 88, 89.

⁸²See *ibid.*, esp. 81–101. Arnold judged (at least, for some time) the French common people to be “more civilized” than their English counterparts, thanks to France’s “equality” and “educational system.” Varouxakis, *Victorian Political Thought on France and the French*, 55–6, 77. Yet he also submitted that “[m]ultitudes, all the world over, have a good deal in common.” Quoted in *ibid.*, 115.

When addressing the 1867 electoral reform, Bagehot did not mince his words. In referring to what he branded “the ultra-democratic theory,” he once again stressed the civilizational risks of such a change: “Upon this theory each man is to have one twelve-millionth share in electing a Parliament; the rich and wise are not to have, by explicit law, more votes than the poor and stupid.” Consequently, “moderate” men would be kept out of Parliament and the whole system would fall prey to “the clownish mass.”⁸³ The Liberal historian Goldwin Smith (who was ambivalent about democracy⁸⁴) echoed similar sentiments when he resorted to Roman history to declare that “a disposition towards Caesarism amongst the masses” was beyond “doubt” just as was the fact that “tyranny” was “the more disastrous the larger the basis on which it relies for support.”⁸⁵ Convinced of the pivotal role of intellectuals in guiding Britain, Smith was a typical exponent of the values expressed in the *Saturday Review*. Countenancing gradual franchise reform and promoting “education” as a means to reach it, the *Saturday Review* prized government by the well-educated and intellectually gifted propertied classes. The periodical saw the electoral reform as a righteous act: to enfranchise trustworthy skilled artisans was imperative, especially because it served as a tool with which to prevent the extension of the suffrage to the masses.⁸⁶ Accordingly, already twelve years prior to this outburst, Smith had assuredly stated, “Every sensible man wishes to keep the head of the nation above wild democracy, and to make Government the rule of intelligence, not the rule of the mob.”⁸⁷

Expanding on this perspective, in May 1870 the consistently antidemocratic Bagehot decried the plebiscites of “democratic autocracies” (including Napoleon III’s) as a lethal weapon in the hands of “the people.”⁸⁸ This comment harbored a more fundamental denunciation of the cultural basis of democracy: as Bagehot quipped, “it is the teaching of democracy that the masses should govern the intellect and not the intellect the masses.” Indeed, the vote of the “stupid” had to “count” just as much as that of the “wise,” the peasant’s just as the philosopher’s.⁸⁹ Likewise, at the time of the collapse of Napoleon’s regime, Bagehot reminded his readers that democratic Caesarism meant “the abuse of the confidence reposed by the most ignorant in a great name to hold at bay the reasoned arguments” of the educated class.⁹⁰ Ultimately, dependence on “the wishes of the masses” was “the source of the greatest weakness”⁹¹ since it denoted dependence on people lacking culture and intelligence.

⁸³Walter Bagehot, *The English Constitution* (1867), new edn with an additional chapter (London, 1872), 146–7. The book had first been issued in the format of nine essays published in the *Fortnightly Review* between 15 May 1865 and 1 January 1867.

⁸⁴Smith was part of the same Oxford-based intellectual elite formed of young Liberals as Arnold and Freeman. See Christopher A. Kent, “Smith, Goldwin,” *ODNB* (accessed 7 Oct. 2025).

⁸⁵“The Last Republicans of Rome,” *Daily News*, Wednesday, 15 Jan. 1868, n.p.

⁸⁶See Merle Mowbray Bevington, *Saturday Review 1855–1868* (New York, 1941), 58–60.

⁸⁷“Conservatism and the Carlton Club,” *Saturday Review*, 10 May 1856, 29.

⁸⁸Walter Bagehot, “The Lessons of the Plebiscite” (*The Economist*, 14 May 1870, 594–5), in *The Collected Works of Walter Bagehot*, 4: 143–6, at 143.

⁸⁹*Ibid.*, 145–6.

⁹⁰Walter Bagehot, “The Collapse of Caesarism” (*The Economist*, 20 Aug. 1870, 1028–9), in *The Collected Works of Walter Bagehot*, 4: 155–9, at 155–6.

⁹¹*Ibid.*, 158–9.

These pre-1870 critiques portrayed Caesarism as interwoven with the democratic masses' uncivilized character—so much so that they thought the latter to be the main factor accounting for Napoleon's success. Crucially, the same critique continued to be advanced after Napoleon's demise. The catalyst for it was the Third Reform Act (1884), which in Britain gave the franchise to two men out of every three.⁹²

Post-1870: Seeley–Maine

The downfall of “the Crowned democrat of Europe” came in 1870, following France's internal troubles and her defeat at the hands of Prussia.⁹³ This event, though, did not stop somebody like Bagehot from linking together democracy, Caesarism, and the empowerment of “ignorance” (instead of “instruction” and “knowledge.”)⁹⁴ As he explained in 1872, “The democratic passions gain by fomenting a diffused excitement, and by massing men in concourses.”⁹⁵ Democracy opposed the rule of a talented elite and meant the rule of the “narrow-minded, unintelligent, incurious” numbers.⁹⁶ Since they were “uneducated,” the democratic masses were easily excitable, succumbing to demagogues and manipulators.⁹⁷ More to the point, since “the average intellect and the average culture” of the democratic body were “excessively low,” they—Bagehot concluded—became “enslaved to authority” of the type France had experienced (and still did).⁹⁸

Theoretical consistency was no prerogative of the bigshot Bagehot. It is clearly encapsulated in the statement of the *Coventry Herald* that “the interests of civilisation” were antithetical to “the Bonapartist theory” and to “the principle of Caesarism.”⁹⁹ Less than one year later, despite expounding a sympathetic view of “Louis Napoleon ... [as] by no means a bad Caesar” (he was “a despot” but “not cruel, and certainly was not ignoble”), an opinion piece in the *Pall Mall Gazette* branded “Caesarism” “a bad thing in itself.” The reason given was that it had not only “wasted the lives of many of the best men in the country,” but it had “corrupted the national mind” and had “vulgarized society” altogether.¹⁰⁰ The then conservative *Pall Mall Gazette* made the connection between democracy and Caesarism more explicitly still in a piece from 1875 where “Caesarism” was defined as “[t]he strongest organization of democracy.”¹⁰¹ Four years later, a note in *The Examiner* referred to “the Bonaparte family” as the artificers of the

⁹² See Hawkins, *Victorian Political Culture*, 321–2.

⁹³ For Bagehot's telling definition see Bagehot, “The Emperor of the French,” 105. With the proclamation of the empire's end (1870), Napoleon III settled with his family in England, where he died three years later. See St John-Stevan, “Bagehot,” 26–7.

⁹⁴ Bagehot, *English Constitution*, “Introduction to the Second Edition,” xxi–ii.

⁹⁵ *Ibid.*, xxx.

⁹⁶ *Ibid.*, 6.

⁹⁷ See *ibid.*, “Introduction to the Second Edition,” xxvii–viii, and 256–7.

⁹⁸ *Ibid.*, “Introduction to the Second Edition,” liii, and also e.g. 34, 204.

⁹⁹ “Results of Cæsarism,” *Coventry Herald*, Friday, 2 Sept. 1870, 1.

¹⁰⁰ “The Ex-emperor,” in “Opinion in the Weekly Reviews,” *Pall Mall Gazette*, 18 March 1871, 1035.

¹⁰¹ “Opinion in the Weekly Reviews. Disarmament as a Security for Peace,” *Pall Mall Gazette*, 22 May 1875, 1923.

“well-known” “curious theory of compound democracy and Caesarism.”¹⁰² The affinity between the two was remarked anew in the aftermath of the 1884 Reform Act in various quarters. For instance, besides reminding its readership that “militarism and mob favour, when combined, are the one unerring mark of coming Caesarism,” the *Preston Chronicle* tellingly added, “democracy finds a demagogue who, instead of tongue and pen, fights with spur and sword, and it is all over with popular liberty.” In fact, “The tribune of the people” became “imperator,” with the result that only “an *imperium* pure and simple” survived, whilst “poor liberty, like truth,” had “to go and hide herself in the well.”¹⁰³

Equally fearful for the present and the future of liberty was the Liberal historian John Robert Seeley (1834–95). Seeley attacked democracy by stressing—in terms close to those of Bagehot and Arnold—the intellectually defective disposition of the masses, so glaringly exposed during the Caesarist experience in France.¹⁰⁴ Wary of the risks of extending the franchise to wider portions of the working classes, Seeley pointed to England sleepwalking into the “infirmity” of “young and sanguine democracy.”¹⁰⁵ The latter was a government dominated by the “impulsive, popular mind,” which was “childishly ignorant of the larger political questions.”¹⁰⁶ Seeley considered democracies in their early stages as particularly vulnerable to manipulation due to the masses’ lack of education. This “somnambulist state” was acute in the England before his eyes as “the newly enfranchised classes” had not been prepared to fulfil an active political role. In fact, “the suffrage” was no education: “conferred” on the “entirely untutored,” it caused “error and misconception.”¹⁰⁷ As a Liberal commentator, Seeley underscored that the want of capacity and talent on the part of the shortsighted and materialist masses could easily drag Britain down into the abyss of uncultivated democratic “Napoleonism.”¹⁰⁸

Such a menacing phenomenon was compounded, a disapproving Seeley reflected, by the tendency of many politicians to ask for the masses’ opinion about the “most momentous, and most difficult questions.” In so doing, these statesmen behaved in a populist way, namely *à la* “Robespierre.”¹⁰⁹ Indeed, their conduct confirmed the Caesarist direction in which the new democratic masses led politics. According to Seeley, it was not simply their fickle nature, but their being enslaved to primitive and prejudiced instincts that made the masses incompetent. He insisted that the multitude was swamped by an “utter childishness” vis-à-vis issues surpassing its own immediate circumstances, which rendered its members unfit not just for active politics but for the right to vote too.¹¹⁰

¹⁰²“Political and Social Notes,” *The Examiner*, Saturday, 15 Feb. 1879, 194.

¹⁰³“Our Gallic Neighbours: Change and Improvement,” *Preston Chronicle*, Saturday, 4 June 1887, n.p.

¹⁰⁴See Duncan Bell, *The Idea of Greater Britain: Empire and the Future of World Order, 1860–1900* (Princeton and Oxford, 2007), 164–7.

¹⁰⁵John Robert Seeley, “Political Somnambulism,” *Macmillan’s Magazine* 43 (1880–81), 28–44, at 28; see also *ibid.*, 29–32.

¹⁰⁶*Ibid.*, 30, 42.

¹⁰⁷*Ibid.*, 28–9.

¹⁰⁸*Ibid.*, 39.

¹⁰⁹*Ibid.*, 29.

¹¹⁰*Ibid.*, 30.

Seeley's stance signified that democracy was most destructive when it combined with Caesarism–Napoleonism. Accordingly, he decried the materialistic approach to life of the masses, which, even when harboring “good feelings,” had insufficient intellectual strength to resist “deceivableness.” The most blatant example of this situation was that of France, where the masses had been deceived by the “clever” Napoleon. For Seeley, once the franchise was given to the French populace, the popular “voice” made clear its wishes: “it called Louis Napoleon to the head of affairs,” with the terrible consequences of which everyone was aware.¹¹¹ France's case was typical of what Seeley named “sommnambulism,” to avert which “politics” needed more than “mere good intentions.” As with Cromwellian rule, so with “Napoleonism,” Seeley's verdict was that the many were bewitched by “the man who makes a striking figure on the historical stage.”¹¹² The key reason why they became so spellbound was their serious cultural deficit. Since they enjoyed neither the “leisure to acquire” knowledge nor “the just way of thinking,” the “masses” remained in a state of inferiority to “the middle-class,” which was formed by “most of the best educated men in the country.” In contrast to the “working classes,” the middle classes possessed “prudence” as well as “political sense and tact.”¹¹³ In a nutshell, they were immunized against the virus of Caesarism affecting the lower orders. As he had explained in an earlier essay, to prevent the working classes from falling prey to misleading “utopias,” “a much greater educational movement ought to begin, or rather ought to have begun long since.”¹¹⁴

Despite differences, Seeley's approach to culture and politics resembled Bagehot's and Arnold's in that he too prioritized the role of a clerisy of the mind in steering the nation towards success and safety. As for Bagehot and Arnold, so for Seeley the democratic aspirations of the Caesarist–Napoleonist masses had no place in this political scheme. Above all, these aspirations did not suit these authors' vision of politics because they were deeply antithetical to their ideal of culture. For them, culture meant more than education: it comprised intellectual sensibility, ethical responsibility, and spiritual–moral independence. Hence culture was the opposite of the blinkered mental habits besetting materialistic Victorian Britain—of which the levelling lower orders were once again considered a crude expression.¹¹⁵

These arguments concern the important question of the educability of the masses. In this regard, whereas some thinkers recognized the need for extending education to the poorest social groups as a way of remedying their faulty moral habits and preparing them for democracy, others thought that democratic education instilled in the working classes the dangerous illusion of being able to become like their betters.¹¹⁶

¹¹¹Ibid., 30.

¹¹²Ibid., 39. Seeley had dealt with the “popular” role of Caesar and “the Roman populace” in John Robert Seeley, *Lectures and Essays* (London, 1870), “The Great Roman Revolution,” Ch. 1, 1–31, esp. 1–2, 7.

¹¹³Seeley, “Sommnambulism,” 30. As is well known, Arnold was, by contrast, no less scathing about the middle classes' materialism and philistinism. See Arnold, “Culture and Anarchy,” e.g. 76.

¹¹⁴John Robert Seeley, “Political Education of the Working Classes,” *Macmillan's Magazine* 36 (1877), 143–5, at 145.

¹¹⁵On Arnold's and Seeley's “endowment of research,” through universities and academies, as an antidemocratic move see Jones, *Victorian Political Thought*, 65–6.

¹¹⁶See Cesare Cuttica, “What to Make of Culture and Science in a Democracy? The English Maine versus the Americans Whitman and Dewey,” *Journal of the History of Ideas*, forthcoming.

If, for some commentators, education could succeed in dissuading the masses from embarking upon revolutionary politics or from supporting the kind of sociopolitical experiment Caesarism promoted, for others their educational development could be achieved only in the future.¹¹⁷

Whilst Seeley set forth his antidemocratic positions a few years before the Third Reform Act, the jurist and legal scholar Henry Sumner Maine (1822–88) cast his aspersions on all things democratic (including education) in the immediate aftermath of the new law. Through harsh criticism of plebiscites articulated in *Popular Government* (1885), Maine—an influence on Bagehot¹¹⁸—saw democracy and despotism as interlaced.¹¹⁹ This could be evinced from the events that had embroiled France, an alleged “democracy” where “enormous majorities” had recently provided “a military despot [with] any answer which he desired.”¹²⁰ Maine was adamant that democracy was an excessive form of government that gave “birth to despotism with the greatest facility.”¹²¹ Therefore democracy was not only politically ruinous, but—because it empowered “the masses”—also detrimental to intellectual progress, scientific innovation, technological advancement, and, more broadly, open-mindedness.¹²² Basically, “human improvement” and democratic “political societies” were incompatible. In line with Bagehot, Arnold, and Seeley, Maine too (albeit in more extreme terms) deemed democratic life the antipode of “civilization”¹²³—so much so as to proclaim that in a democratic England “[t]he threshing-machine, the power-loom, the spinning-jenny, and possibly the steam-engine, would have been prohibited.”¹²⁴

To substantiate his statement, Maine resorted to historical iterations of democratic Caesarism. First, he stressed that the years 1792, 1830, and 1848 had witnessed the Parisian “mobs” at their subversive worst, as a result of which “a rigid despotism” had ensued.¹²⁵ Second, he asserted that since the time when “the Roman Emperors were at the mercy of the Praetorian soldiery, there has been no such insecurity of government as the world has seen since rulers became delegates of the community.”¹²⁶ What all of this proved was that, although “[t]he convinced partisans of democracy” denied it,

¹¹⁷The 1870 Education Act was a first, albeit limited, step in this direction. On some of these themes, see e.g. Catherine Hall, *Civilising Subjects: Metropole and Colony in the English Imagination, 1830–1867* (Cambridge, 2002), esp. 424–33.

¹¹⁸See John W. Burrow, *Whigs and Liberals: Continuity and Change in English Political Thought* (Oxford, 1988), 109.

¹¹⁹Despite not using “Caesarism,” Maine talked a great deal about Napoleon’s regime in relation to democracy.

¹²⁰Henry Sumner Maine, *Popular Government*, with an introduction by George W. Carey (Indianapolis, 1976), 110. *Popular Government* derived from four essays published in the *Quarterly Review*: “Prospects of Popular Government” (April 1883), “Constitution of the U.S.” (Jan. 1884), “Nature of Democracy” (Oct. 1884), and “Age of Progress” (April 1885).

¹²¹Maine, *Popular Government*, 190.

¹²²*Ibid.*, 112. See also *ibid.*, 58–9, 87, 155, 191–2.

¹²³*Ibid.*, 63.

¹²⁴*Ibid.*, 112.

¹²⁵*Ibid.*, 43, 40.

¹²⁶*Ibid.*, 45–6.

instability was part and parcel of democratic government.¹²⁷ The keynote of Maine's antidemocratic critique was the new role the intellectually deficient and spiritually flawed masses had assumed in Britain's post-1884 public arena. As he explicated in a gambit reminiscent of Arnold, from being "a portion of society in a state of dissolution," loosened from harmonious societal bonds and crippled by "mischief," "disorder," and "panic," a "mob" had become a group with "definite opinions."¹²⁸ The masses had acquired their own zealous identity anchored in the belief of their own righteousness, which made them fanatically immune to "doubt." This development was "a product of democratic sentiment," of which the Caesarist Cromwell represented a major historical embodiment.¹²⁹ In support of his thesis stood recent events too: if the French had disposed of "universal suffrage" after the Terror, it had nonetheless been "twice revived in France, that the Napoleonic tyranny might be founded on it," and the same had occurred in Germany, so that "the personal power of Bismarck might be confirmed."¹³⁰ As the *coup d'état* of Louis-Napoleon had amply shown, the plebiscite constituted "the very principle of democracy."¹³¹ Therefore, on Maine's telling, Caesarism–Napoleonism was the political regime that wickedly housed under the same roof talentless people and regressive governance, signaling the end of civilized life in the polity¹³²—for Maine, even "education" could not improve things when it came to democracy and its narrow-minded masses.¹³³

In a Britain embracing democratic politics more decisively than ever before, these views made headway beyond the world of political writings. An article by W. Earl Hodgson in *Time* (1885) affirmed that, "With its faulty aims and doings," "its Caesarism," "its monstrous beliefs," and "its sham philanthropy," "Democracy" (a "degeneration") was "a political intoxication into which the masses have been seduced by men seeking to profit by the consequent excitement and confusion."¹³⁴ Above all, according to Hodgson, "Democracy is a malady; and very much more than it, Democracy is a curse to civilisation," giving an uneducated individual the illusion of being able to have an opinion, and even take decisions, about his country's affairs.¹³⁵

By the same token, the 7th Earl Cowper, a leading Liberal grandee, wrote that "the degeneration of the people" that came with "democracy" was accompanied by "Caesarism."¹³⁶ Most importantly, Cowper too adopted Polybius' theory, according to which "a monarchy is succeeded by an oligarchy; an oligarchy, after a more or less prolonged struggle, by a democracy; and a democracy by the dominion of an autocrat." When underlining "the chief difference between the king who begins the series, and

¹²⁷ Ibid., 45.

¹²⁸ Ibid., 48.

¹²⁹ Ibid., 49–50.

¹³⁰ Ibid., 57. For Maine, "universal suffrage" constituted "the natural basis of a tyranny." Ibid., 56.

¹³¹ Ibid., 61.

¹³² See Frank Prochaska, *Eminent Victorians on American Democracy: The View from Albion* (Oxford, 2012), 75.

¹³³ See "The Foundations of Modern Society," *Pall Mall Gazette*, 1 April 1871, 1225.

¹³⁴ W. Earl Hodgson, "Party Organisation: The Curse of the Country," *Time* 12/10 (1885), 395–409, at 403.

¹³⁵ Ibid., 407, 408.

¹³⁶ "Caesarism," *Nineteenth Century* 17/95 (1885), 1–14, at 2.

the despot who ends it,” Cowper clarified that the peculiar nature of democratic despotism was for “the despot” to rely “upon the people whose power he has appropriated.”¹³⁷ Like his earlier Victorian counterparts, Cowper was convinced that, without the perseverance of intelligent and cultivated MPs resisting Caesarism, a deterioration was inevitable. Having first maintained that England’s “national life” was imperiled, and having predicted “that the addition to our constituencies of 2,000,000 voters belonging to the most ignorant and impulsive of our population will for the moment intensify the evil of which I have spoken,”¹³⁸ Cowper concluded on a more hopeful note: whether “democracy takes a wrong direction and ends in a repetition of the old story” or, instead, “democracy takes a right direction and keeps clear of Caesarism” was uncertain.¹³⁹ Once again, much seemed to hinge on whether culture could stymie the growth of “shouting” and “eloquence,” which was “one of the diseases to which democracy is liable,” and protect Britain from the claws of Caesarism.¹⁴⁰

Eleven years later, these opinions were still common. Not only was it argued that “to identify parliamentary government with democracy” was naive as “the connexion of the two things is rather habitual than necessary,” and that, since “parliamentary government” was in disrepute and “government by the people at large” was “impracticable,” the solution had come from France, where people had endorsed “a man as interpreter of the mass.”¹⁴¹ It was also contended that “the legend of Napoleon” was “that of Caesar,” being “the Latin idea of representation of the people by a single man of genius.” Thus “Caesarism” meant “representation of the mass by a man.”¹⁴² “Curiously enough,” it was “England, rather than France,” that was “developing the conditions of a true Caesarism.” Worse, England was creating “the machinery for a popular dictatorship.”¹⁴³ For this author, too, Caesarism was more than the manifestation of a *grand homme*. It was the democratic nourishment of “a dictator responsible to the people.”¹⁴⁴

Conclusion

This article has shown that Caesarism was extensively discussed in Victorian Britain, where it represented one modality by which mass democracy was decried—as happened in the contexts of the Second (1867) and Third Reform Acts (1884). It has

¹³⁷ Ibid., 3. See also *ibid.*, 7.

¹³⁸ Ibid., 12–13.

¹³⁹ Ibid., 14.

¹⁴⁰ Ibid., 13. That democracy drowned judicious voices in the foolish oratory of “the idle multitude” was a stance that had been forcefully expounded more than thirty years earlier in Thomas Carlyle, “The Present Time. No. I. February 1850,” in Carlyle, *Latter-Day Pamphlets* (London 1850), 1–56, at 12. Bagehot shared similar worries about the potentially demagogic turn of democratic oratory. See Stefan Collini, Donald Winch and John W. Burrow, *That Noble Science of Politics: A Study in Nineteenth-Century Intellectual History* (Cambridge, 1983), 180. For the opinion that a “General Boulanger” might take hold of England see “Boulangism in England: A Speculation,” *Macmillan’s Magazine* 59 (1888), 31–5.

¹⁴¹ “Modern Caesarism,” *Saturday Review*, 25 Feb. 1899, 230–31.

¹⁴² Ibid., 231.

¹⁴³ Yet England—which frequently meant Britain—was equipped with “the means” to “control” it. Ibid., 231.

¹⁴⁴ Ibid., 231.

suggested that intellectuals such as Walter Bagehot, Matthew Arnold, John Robert Seeley, and Henry Sumner Maine (as well as various less well-known political commentators) connected—explicitly or indirectly—Caesarism–Napoleonism with the uncultured masses’ materialistic preoccupations, superstitious prejudices, and spiritual poverty. Most importantly, it has underlined that since, for these authors, culture entailed values such as openness, emancipation, responsibility, and character, their criticism of Caesarism needs to be read as part of a broader discourse whereby democracy was detrimental to (a certain idea of) civilization.

The article has complexified the standard historiographical picture according to which Caesarism was mostly the affair of a charismatic military leader. It has done so by understanding Caesarism as a cultural category rather than exclusively as a political doctrine. Accordingly, it has claimed that Victorian attacks on democratic Caesarism were undergirded by an array of axioms that reflected a normative vision of personal independence, civic liberty, and collective behavior. This reading has revealed how Caesarism–Napoleonism served to pinpoint the contours of democracy’s excessive character. Caesarism and mass democracy completed each other in that the former was a form of politics and of societal life within which the irrational beliefs of the latter could find the most extreme expression.

Furthermore, the article has proved that negative assessments of democratic Caesarism remained consistent between the 1850s and the 1890s. They had one principal target in their crosshairs: the democratic masses’ cultural deficiencies and (consequent) want of political vision, whose effects on state and society were nefariously *Caesarist*. Irrespective of political orientation, our authors all concurred that a lethal mixture of extreme carelessness, petty self-interestedness and utter boorishness led the masses to place a Caesar at their head. In a nutshell, for many Victorian critics, Caesarism was made possible because democracy was a cultural–spiritual desert whose aridity killed the intellect altogether, facilitating the empowerment of Napoleon-like figures.

Finally, the article has contributed to the study of Victorian ideas of democracy. Against the grain of much scholarship—where these ideas are examined in conjunction with parliamentary debates, constitutional developments, party politics, and canonical works¹⁴⁵—it has focused on a specifically *cultural* critique of democracy that was articulated in different sources (including some that are little considered in the history of political thought). By focusing on Caesarism, this critique laid bare the considerable extent to which democracy was dreaded. This is to say that Victorian debates about democracy were not simply about governments or legal–institutional arrangements. They circled around moral values, class-related anxieties, and philosophical arguments that addressed the burning question of how a *dangerous uncouth* mass could be turned into a *respectable polished* citizenry. In the eyes of intellectuals such as Bagehot, Arnold, Seeley, and Maine, just as in those of less sophisticated observers, the looming specter of British Caesarism did not bode well for the success of such a transformation.

¹⁴⁵For a similar stance to mine see Robert Saunders, “Introduction: ‘Shooting Niagara—and After?’”, in Saunders, ed., “Shooting Niagara—and After?” *The Second Reform Act and Its World, Parliamentary History*, 36/1 (2017), 1–13, at 10, 11 n. 39.

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